FRAMING OF THE CONFLICT: MOVING BEYOND THE CANON OF ETHNIC IDENTITY

One of the starkest observations made during our research was that all local informants and a majority of international analysts framed their responses in terms of 'ethnic conflict', even though we carefully avoided such terminology during the research so as not to prejudice responses and analysis. Informants who identified as Kachin exclusively framed the conflict as ethnic, regularly adopting terms such as 'the Kachin', Bamar, and Tatmadaw as if distinct, homogenous, and exclusive parties. Most of the literature on conflicts in Myanmar, including the Kachin conflict, frames them in terms of ethnic identity and race in a similar manner.

Recent scholarship has heavily criticized the oversimplification of conflict as 'ethnic', suggesting that such portrayals largely fail to recognize the diversity of actors and identities, and tends to consider identities as distinct, binary, and enduring social categories. The 'ethnic' assumption for the study of conflict in Myanmar is in tune with an established analytical framework for the study of internal conflict and civil wars along identity lines, with the tendency to encompass all members of an 'ethnic' group as parts of the conflict (Cordell and Wolff 2010; Esman 2004; Gurr and Harff 1994; Wolff 2006). This line of analysis starts with a presupposition that 'ethnic identities' exist as distinct social categories, and that tensions caused by differences in identities constitute the primary source of collective violence and conflict. Analysis thus attempts to unveil the exact types and nature of ethnic identities, and the structure and patterns which lead to inequality and conflict.

Ethnic identities and nationalisms do not exist in a vacuum, but emerge in response to particular and dynamic sociopolitical contexts. Lived ethnic identity and sociocultural tradition is inherently fluid, diverse, and riven by division. The danger is, however, that the polarizing narratives used to mobilize nationalism mean that using the term in relation to conflict almost inevitably implies an inelasticity and staticism of internally homogenous and externally bounded groups that does not reflect the realities of the social world (Malešević 2004). Conflation of conflict into an 'ethnic' label also tends to engage all members of collectivities as part of the conflict, when in reality only a segment may be involved, and may interpolate elements into a unified whole, erasing or ignoring distinctions and difference (Gilley 2004; Murer 2012).